

? How Phishing Works

On November 17, 2003, many eBay customers received an e-mail notification that their accounts had been compromised and were being restricted. Included in the message was a link to what appeared to be an eBay Web page for re-registration.

The top of the page looked just like eBay's home page and incorporated all the internal links. To re-register, customers were asked to provide credit card data, ATM personal identification numbers, Social Security numbers, dates of birth and mother's maiden names.

Fact is, eBay hadn't sent the original e-mail and the Web page didn't belong to them either. Many who received the e-mail carried out the recommended actions, in the process, giving away vital ID secrets.

knows. Examples of machine readable biometrics are fingerprints, retinal or iris patterns, hand geometries and facial features. A secure token is a physical device: an example is USB secure tokens, which are designed to store a person's digital identity. When someone attempts to log in to applications via a PC, virtual private network, or wireless network, he or she is prompted to enter a unique PIN. If the number matches that on the USB token, access is granted. The number stored on the token is encrypted for additional security.

The most secure method of identification is "two-factor authentication". This would be something like a PIN plus something you have (a key or an access card). Biometrics adds levels of security by combining something you know with something you are (for example, a fingerprint). Additional levels of security can be implemented by added factors such as a username and password plus a biometric and a token.

Be Very Afraid...

Cases of ID theft abound; some more mentionable than others. In one notorious case in the early '90s in the US, the thief was a convicted felon. He not only incurred more than Rs 43.5 lakh in credit card debt, he obtained a home loan, and bought homes, motorcycles, and handguns in the victim's name. The icing on the cake was that he called his victim to taunt him, saying he could continue to pose as him for as long as he wanted. ID theft was not a crime.

While the victim and his wife spent more than four years and over Rs 6.5 lakh to restore their credit and reputation, the criminal served only a brief sentence for making false statements to procure a firearm.

This case prompted the US Congress in 1998 to create a new Federal offence of identity theft. Creating an offence of it is one thing, but ID theft is a low-risk and high-payoff crime.

There are several pieces of information that make up an identity; we need to realise that each of these pieces is potentially valuable information, and we need to overhaul the way we communicate and exchange this information.

In the long run, technology could come to the rescue. Before that, the problem will loom on us until every last one of us keeps every bit of personal information under lock and key, and shreds it before throwing it away—physically and virtually. Paranoia is the need of the times. You have to pretend like someone's looking over your shoulder all the time. ☒

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